

 Part 1 – Question Paper**10-Mark Questions**

1. Explain the complete working mechanism and structural components of the MD5 (Message Digest Algorithm 5).
2. Discuss the Secure Hash Algorithm (SHA) family, detailing its core features and various versions.
3. Analyse the concept of Digital Signatures, focusing on their purpose, cryptographic basis, and legal significance.
4. Examine the Digital Signature Standard (DSS), explaining its importance and key functional components.
5. Detail the comprehensive verification process for Digital Signatures and the role of trusted platforms.

5-Mark Questions

6. Explain the padding and appending steps involved in preparing a message for hashing.
7. Describe the different types of Authentication Protocols used to verify identity.
8. Compare and contrast: Hashing vs. Encryption.
9. Explain the role and importance of Digital Signing Certificates and Certificate Authorities (CAs).
10. Describe the SHA-2 family and why it superseded SHA-1 in modern security applications.
11. Discuss the specific features of SHA that ensure data integrity and uniqueness.
12. Explain the process of initializing MD buffers and dividing messages into sub-blocks.
13. Describe the operational rounds and variables used in the SHA-512 algorithm.

2-Mark Questions

14. Define MD5 and state its fixed digest size.
15. What is meant by a hash collision?
16. Briefly define the Digital Signature Algorithm (DSA).
17. What is Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)?
18. Define non-repudiation in the context of digital signatures.
19. What are the four 32-bit buffers used in MD5 initialization?
20. Define biometric authentication.
21. What is the deterministic nature of SHA?
22. State the primary difference between SHA-1 and SHA-3.
23. What is an audit trail in e-signature platforms?
24. Who created MD5 and for what primary purpose?
25. What happens if a recipient cannot open a document with a signer's public key?

EXAM POV NOTES (Q&A FORMAT)

✦ Part 2 – Complete Answer Bank

10-Mark Questions

Q1. Explain the complete working mechanism and structural components of the MD5 (Message Digest Algorithm 5).

MD5 is a cryptographic hash function that processes an input of any length to produce a fixed 128-bit output, often used to verify digital signatures.

- **Algorithm Origin:** Ronald Rivest created the MD5 method in 1991 to specifically enable the verification of digital signatures. Since its inception, it has been integrated into numerous security frameworks to enhance data protection measures across various digital environments.
- **Fixed Digest Output:** The algorithm always produces a 128-bit digest, regardless of the length of the input string provided by the user. This consistency is essential for standardising hash results, which are typically represented as 32-digit hexadecimal numbers for easier system processing.
- **Collision Resistance Goal:** The fixed output size and internal logic are designed to reduce the chance of hash collisions, which occur when similar hashes are formed from different inputs. Even a minor change to the input string will result in a considerably different digest value.
- **Padding Bit Verification:** Upon receiving an input string, the system must verify that the string's size is 64 bits less than a multiple of 512. This specific mathematical alignment is required before the actual hashing rounds can begin to ensure the data fits the algorithm's block structure.
- **Padding Bit Composition:** In order to round off the extra characters to the required length, the algorithm adds a single '1' bit followed by zeroes. This process ensures that the message reaches a length that is compatible with the final appending of the original message's length.
- **Padding Length Representation:** To achieve a final length that is a multiple of 512, the original input's length is represented as 64 bits. This bit-representation of the original size is then combined with the padded string to prepare the final data for hashing.
- **Buffer Initialization:** The mechanism requires the initialisation of four 32-bit buffers known as A, B, C, and D. These buffers act as the working registers that store intermediate values as the algorithm processes each segment of the message.
- **Buffer Constant Values:** Each of the four buffers is initialised with specific hexadecimal constants: A=01 23 45 67, B=89 ab cd ef, C=fe dc ba 98, and D=76 54 32 10. These predefined values provide a consistent starting point for the mathematical transformations.
- **Message Block Division:** The entire prepared string is divided into several blocks, each having 512 bits. Each block is then processed individually through the hashing function to ensure large datasets can be handled systematically and securely.

- **Sub-block Processing:** Every 512-bit block is further divided into 16 sub-blocks of 32 bits each, identified as M through M. These sub-blocks are used across four operation rounds alongside constant array values (T to T) to produce the final digest.

Q2. Discuss the Secure Hash Algorithm (SHA) family, detailing its core features and various versions.

The SHA family consists of cryptographic hash functions designed to compress input data into a smaller, incomprehensible form using bitwise operations and modular additions.

- **Algorithm Classification:** SHA stands for secure hashing algorithm and is considered a modified, more advanced version of the MD5 framework. It is primarily used to hash data and digital certificates to ensure they cannot be easily decoded or tampered with by unauthorised parties.
- **One-Way Nature:** A defining feature of SHA is that it is strictly one-way, meaning that once data has been hashed, it cannot be reversed. To break the resulting hash digest, an attacker would need to perform a computationally expensive brute force attack.
- **SHA-0 and SHA-1 Evolution:** The original specification, SHA-0, was published in 1993 by NIST but was quickly withdrawn and superseded by SHA-1. SHA-1 produces a 160-bit hash value, rendered as a 40-digit hexadecimal number, though it is now considered less secure.
- **The SHA-2 Family:** SHA-2 includes several hash functions with digest sizes of 224, 256, 384, or 512 bits. These versions are more secure than SHA-1 and are currently the standard for SSL certificates and various modern security applications.
- **SHA-3 Innovation:** As the newest member of the family, SHA-3 was created using entirely different methods than its predecessors. It also offers multiple digest sizes (224, 256, 384, 512) and provides an alternative mathematical structure to enhance long-term security.
- **Data Integrity Assurance:** SHA is designed to verify the integrity of data by generating a fixed-size result from an input of arbitrary size. If the hash values of a file match over time, it suggests that the data has not been altered or corrupted.
- **Deterministic Property:** One of the key features of SHA is its deterministic nature, which ensures consistency across systems. This means any computer or user will reproduce the exact same hash digest as long as they use the same algorithm and input.
- **Collision Resistance:** Modern SHA versions are specifically designed to reduce the probability of collisions, where two different inputs produce the same hash. While theoretically possible, it is computationally challenging for attackers to find such pairs in SHA-256 or SHA-3.
- **Cryptographic Security:** SHA is engineered to resist various cryptographic attacks, including pre-image and second pre-image attacks. This complexity makes it extremely difficult for an attacker to reverse-engineer the original data from the hash value.
- **High Efficiency:** Despite their security, SHA algorithms are computationally efficient, allowing them to produce hash values quickly even for massive amounts of data. This speed makes them ideal for blockchain technology and real-time digital signatures.

Q3. Analyse the concept of Digital Signatures, focusing on their purpose, cryptographic basis, and legal significance

A digital signature is a mathematical technique used to validate the authenticity and integrity of digital documents, serving as the electronic equivalent of a handwritten signature.

- **Security Purpose:** The primary intent of a digital signature is to solve the problem of tampering and impersonation in digital communications. It provides much higher inherent security than a physical seal by ensuring that a message remains in its original state.
- **Evidence of Identity:** Digital signatures provide verifiable evidence of origin and identity for electronic documents and transactions. They allow the recipient to be certain of who sent the message and the current status of the digital communication.
- **Asymmetric Cryptography Basis:** These signatures are based on public key cryptography, which utilizes two different but mathematically linked keys. This system, also known as asymmetric cryptography, is the foundation for secure electronic identification.
- **RSA Algorithm Utilization:** Algorithms such as Rivest-Shamir-Adleman (RSA) are used to generate the keys. This process creates a private key that remains with the signer and a public key that is shared with recipients to verify the signature.
- **Private Key Encryption:** To create a signature, the signer uses their private key to encrypt signature-related data. This ensures that only the holder of the private key could have generated that specific digital mark, providing proof of authorship.
- **Public Key Decryption:** The only way to decrypt the signature data is with the signer's public key. If the recipient can open the document using this key, it authenticates the signature as legitimate and belonging to the purported sender.
- **Detection of Problems:** If a recipient cannot open a document with the public key, it indicates a problem with the document or the signature. This failure is the primary mechanism for detecting fraudulent or corrupted files.
- **Role of Certificates:** Digital signing certificates, issued by trusted Certificate Authorities (CAs) like DocuSign, are used to verify that a public key belongs to the issuer. These certificates include owner info, expiration dates, and the CA's signature.
- **Non-repudiation Property:** A digital signature provides proof of non-repudiation, meaning the signer cannot later deny having signed the document. This provides legal certainty to all parties involved in an electronic transaction.
- **Legal Binding Status:** In many countries, such as the U.S., digital signatures are considered legally binding in the same way as traditional handwritten signatures. This legal recognition allows for the fully electronic execution of contracts and official records.

Q4. Examine the Digital Signature Standard (DSS), explaining its importance and key functional components.

The Digital Signature Standard (DSS) is a federal standard in the United States, defined by NIST, that specifies algorithms for creating and verifying digital signatures.

- **Regulatory Framework:** DSS is defined by the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) to secure electronic transactions and communications. It serves as the mandatory guideline for many federal agencies to ensure data authenticity.
- **Standardization Importance:** DSS provides a standardised method for digital signatures, which ensures consistency across different industries. This uniformity is vital for maintaining security and trust in large-scale electronic transactions.
- **Security Assurance:** The standard specifies secure cryptographic algorithms like the Digital Signature Algorithm (DSA). This ensures that signatures generated under this standard are highly resistant to forgery and unauthorised tampering.
- **Compliance Requirements:** For many federal agencies, DSS is a strict requirement for regulatory compliance. It ensures that all digital signatures meet a baseline of security and authenticity mandated by government standards.
- **Interoperability Role:** A major benefit of DSS is promoting interoperability across different systems. It ensures that a signature created on one platform can be successfully verified on another, facilitating secure collaboration.
- **DSA Core Component:** The Digital Signature Algorithm (DSA) is the primary component of DSS used for generating signatures. It provides the mathematical steps necessary to ensure reliable and secure document signing.
- **Key Pair Management:** DSS relies on the use of public and private key pairs to manage access. This component ensures that only the authorised individual with the private key can actually sign the electronic document.
- **Data Integrity via Hashing:** The standard uses cryptographic hash functions to create a unique fingerprint of a document. This ensures that the data remains intact, as any change to the document would result in a different hash.
- **Standardised Verification Process:** DSS outlines a clear verification process for the recipient. By using the signer's public key, the recipient can confirm that the signature is legitimate and the document is untampered.
- **Authenticity Guarantee:** The functional components of DSS work together to guarantee the authenticity of the signer. This prevents impersonation and ensures that the digital identity of the sender is mathematically verified.

Q5. Detail the comprehensive verification process for Digital Signatures and the role of trusted platforms.

The verification of a digital signature involves several technical steps and the use of trusted third-party platforms to ensure the document is authentic and legally binding.

- **Certificate Status Check:** The first step in the process is to check the digital ID certificate status of the signature. A validator must confirm that the certificate is currently active and has not been revoked or expired.
- **Trust Validation:** A validator checks if the signer's certificate is trusted by a recognised authority. This often involves verifying the entire chain of certificates back to a root authority that all parties trust.

- **Document Integrity Verification:** The system ensures that the document's content has not been altered or corrupted since it was signed. This is typically achieved by comparing the original hash with a newly generated one.
- **Audit Trail Review:** Many e-signature platforms maintain an audit trail that documents the signing process. This trail provides additional chronological evidence that can be used to prove the signature's validity in court.
- **Private Key Application:** The verification process acknowledges that the private key was used by the signer to generate the initial signature. This step is the "signing" phase that creates the unique encrypted data.
- **Public Key Application:** The recipient completes the process by using the public key to verify the signature. This mathematical check is the only way to confirm that the corresponding private key was used.
- **Signer Intent Review:** A critical non-technical step is verifying the signer's intention to be bound by the document's terms. This confirms that the person signed the document purposefully and with informed consent.
- **Role of Trusted Platforms:** Using trusted e-signature platforms like Dropbox Sign adds a layer of assurance. These platforms adhere to strict legal and technical standards to ensure signatures are durable and valid.
- **Authenticity Proof:** A successful verification confirms that the document was indeed created by the person whose certificate is attached. This provides the "who" in the digital transaction.
- **Non-repudiation Assurance:** The completed process provides proof that prevents the signer from denying their signature. This finality is essential for the legal enforcement of electronic agreements and contracts.

5-Mark Questions

Q6. Explain the padding and appending steps involved in preparing a message for hashing.

Preparing a message for hashing requires adjusting its length through padding and appending to meet the algorithm's block size requirements.

- **Padding Bit Verification:** When a string is received, the algorithm first verifies if the size is 64 bits less than a multiple of 512. This is a prerequisite for the mathematical operations that follow in the hashing process.
- **Addition of '1' and Zeroes:** To round off the extra characters, the system adds a single '1' bit followed by the necessary number of zeroes. This ensures the message reaches the specific bit-length required for the next step.
- **Original Length Representation:** The algorithm calculates the original input's length and represents it as a 64-bit value. This value is preserved to ensure the hash accurately reflects the original data's size.
- **Final String Combination:** The 64-bit length is combined with the padded string to form the final message. This combined string is now exactly a multiple of 512 bits in length.

- **Hashing Readiness:** Once these steps are complete, the last string is fully prepared for hashing. The data is now formatted into blocks that the internal compression functions of MD5 or SHA can process.

Q7. Describe the different types of Authentication Protocols used to verify identity

Authentication protocols are standard procedures designed to verify the identity of users or systems and ensure only authorised access to protected resources.

- **Password-based Authentication:** This is the most common form of authentication, where a user provides a username and a secret password. While simple to implement, it is vulnerable to dictionary and brute force attacks.
- **Two-factor Authentication (2FA):** This protocol provides an additional layer of security by requiring two forms of identification. For example, a user might need both a password and a physical security token to log in.
- **Biometric Authentication:** This highly secure method uses physical or behavioural characteristics like fingerprints or facial recognition. While very secure, it can be expensive and may not work perfectly for every user.
- **Prevention of Unauthorised Access:** All these protocols share the goal of preventing unauthorised access or tampering. They serve as the digital gatekeepers that protect sensitive information from malicious actors.
- **Infrastructure and Convenience:** Choosing a protocol involves balancing security, infrastructure costs, and user convenience. For instance, 2FA is more secure than passwords alone but can be seen as inconvenient for daily use.

Q8. Compare and contrast: Hashing vs. Encryption.

Hashing and encryption are both cryptographic tools used for security, but they differ fundamentally in their reversibility and purpose.

Feature	Hashing	Encryption
Direction	One-way process; data cannot be easily decoded.	Generally a two-way process designed for decryption.
Recovery	Needs a brute force attack to break the digest.	Designed to be recovered using a specific key.
Core Function	Compresses data into a smaller, incomprehensible form.	Protects data for secure transmission between parties.
Integrity vs. Privacy	Primarily used to verify data integrity.	Primarily used to ensure data privacy.
Algorithm Used	Uses bitwise operations and compression functions.	Uses asymmetric keys (Public/Private) for access.

Q9. Explain the role and importance of Digital Signing Certificates and Certificate Authorities (CAs).

Digital signing certificates and CAs form the trust infrastructure that allows public keys to be reliably associated with specific individuals.

- **Identity Verification:** Digital signing certificates (public key certificates) are used to verify that a public key belongs to the claimed issuer. This prevents attackers from distributing fake keys.
- **Certificate Contents:** These certificates are sent alongside the public key and contain vital information. This includes the owner's identity, expiration dates, and the digital signature of the issuer.
- **Role of the CA:** Trusted third-party Certificate Authorities (CAs), such as GlobalSign or DocuSign, are the entities that issue these certificates. They act as the "notaries" of the digital world.
- **Prevention of Fraud:** CAs help prevent fraudulent digital signatures by ensuring that only verified individuals receive signing certificates. This maintains the integrity of the entire signing system.
- **Trust Requirement:** The entire technology relies on trust between all parties involved. Users must trust that the CA has done its job and that the signer has kept their private key secret.

Q10. Describe the SHA-2 family and why it superseded SHA-1 in modern security applications.

SHA-2 is a collection of hash functions that became the industry standard after SHA-1 was found to have security weaknesses.

- **Variety of Digest Sizes:** The SHA-2 family includes functions with digests of 224, 256, 384, or 512 bits. This allows for higher security margins compared to the 160-bit limit of SHA-1.
- **Security Vulnerabilities of SHA-1:** Since 2005, SHA-1 has not been considered secure against well-funded opponents. Weaknesses were found that could potentially allow for hash collisions.
- **NIST Deprecation:** Due to these risks, NIST formally deprecated SHA-1 in 2011 and disallowed its use for digital signatures by 2013. This regulatory move forced a shift to SHA-2.
- **SSL Certificate Standards:** Currently, all SSL certificates on the Internet must use SHA-2. This industry-wide mandate ensures that web communications are protected by modern, robust hashing.
- **Enhanced Design:** SHA-2 includes significant changes from its predecessor, SHA-1. These internal improvements make it far more resistant to the types of attacks that compromised earlier versions.

Q11. Discuss the specific features of SHA that ensure data integrity and uniqueness.

SHA uses specific mathematical properties, such as fixed-size results and deterministic logic, to provide a reliable way to identify and verify data.

- **Data Integrity Verification:** SHA generates a fixed-size hash from any size of input. If even one letter in the original message changes, the resulting hash will be significantly different, alerting the user to the alteration.
- **Uniqueness Property:** The algorithm strives to produce unique hash results for different inputs. Modern versions are specifically designed to make it theoretically improbable for two different inputs to result in the same hash.

- **Deterministic Logic:** A key feature is its deterministic nature, meaning the same input will always produce the same hash on any system. This allows for consistent verification across different computers.
- **Avalanche Effect:** SHA is intended to provide a unique hash even if only a single character changes (e.g., "Heaven" vs "heaven"). This sensitivity ensures that any tiny modification is immediately visible.
- **Resistance to Reversal:** Because hashing is one-way and compresses data, it is challenging for an attacker to reverse-engineer the original data. This ensures the unique hash cannot be used to recover the input.

Q12. Explain the process of initializing MD buffers and dividing messages into sub-blocks.

Introduction: The MD5 algorithm organises data into blocks and sub-blocks while using pre-set buffers to maintain the state of the hash calculation.

- **Block Segmentation:** The entire input string is divided into several 512-bit blocks. This division allows the algorithm to process the message in uniform, manageable chunks.
- **Buffer Initialization:** The algorithm initialises four 32-bit buffers identified as A, B, C, and D. These registers hold the evolving hash value as each block is processed.
- **Specific Buffer Constants:** These buffers are set to standard hexadecimal values (e.g., A=01 23 45 67). These constants are a fixed part of the MD5 specification to ensure reproducibility.
- **Sub-block Division:** Each large 512-bit block is further split into 16 sub-blocks. Each of these smaller sub-blocks contains exactly 32 bits of data from the original message.
- **Sub-block Notation:** These sub-blocks are identified by the notation M through M. They are used sequentially in the four rounds of operations to transform the values in buffers A through D.

Q13. Describe the operational rounds and variables used in the SHA-512 algorithm.

SHA-512 uses a specific series of processing steps involving multiple variables and rounds to produce a high-security 512-bit hash.

- **Chaining Variables:** The process begins by initialising 5 chaining variables. These variables are essential for maintaining the state of the hash across multiple blocks of data.
- **Variable Mapping:** During processing, the algorithm copies corresponding variables (A=a, B=b, C=c, D=d, and E=e). This internal mapping is used to track transformations within each step.
- **Input Block Size:** In SHA-512, the input is divided into blocks of 1024 bits. (Note: While SHA-1 uses 512-bit blocks, the larger SHA-512 uses 1024-bit blocks for its 64-bit word operations).
- **Round Structure:** The processing of blocks involves four major rounds of operations. These rounds ensure that the input bits are thoroughly mixed and scrambled into the final hash.
- **Step Intensity:** Each of the four rounds consists of 20 steps, resulting in a total of 80 steps for each block of data. This high number of steps provides significant security against cryptographic attacks.

2-Mark Questions

Q14. Define MD5 and state its fixed digest size.

- **Definition:** MD5 is a cryptographic hash algorithm that creates a 32-digit hexadecimal digest from a string of any length.
- **Digest Size:** It always produces a fixed 128-bit digest.

Q15. What is meant by a hash collision?

- **Definition:** A collision is the formation of similar or identical hashes from two different input messages.
- **Security Impact:** Modern SHA versions are designed to reduce the probability of this occurring to ensure data uniqueness.

Q16. Briefly define the Digital Signature Algorithm (DSA).

- **Definition:** DSA is a cryptographic algorithm specified by DSS used for generating and verifying digital signatures.
- **Role:** It ensures the integrity and authenticity of electronic documents and transactions.

Q17. What is Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)?

- **Definition:** It is an authentication protocol requiring two forms of identification (e.g., a password and a token) to verify a user's identity.
- **Benefit:** It provides an additional layer of security over standard password-based methods.

Q18. Define non-repudiation in the context of digital signatures.

- **Definition:** It is a property that provides proof that a signer is the one who signed a document.
- **Impact:** It prevents the signer from later denying their signature on a document or transaction.

Q19. What are the four 32-bit buffers used in MD5 initialization?

- **Buffers:** The four initialised 32-bit buffers are A, B, C, and D.
- **Initial Values:** They are set to hexadecimal constants starting with A=01 23 45 67 and ending with D=76 54 32 10.

Q20. Define biometric authentication.

- **Definition:** This is a type of authentication that uses physical or behavioural characteristics to verify identity.
- **Examples:** Common methods include the use of fingerprints or facial recognition.

Q21. What is the deterministic nature of SHA?

- **Definition:** It means any computer or user will reproduce the exact same hash digest as long as they use the same algorithm and input.
- **Importance:** This consistency allows for the reliable verification of data across different systems.

Q22. State the primary difference between SHA-1 and SHA-3.

- **Methodology:** SHA-3 was created using different methods than the earlier SHA-1 and SHA-2 versions.
- **Security Status:** SHA-1 is currently considered less secure due to known weaknesses, whereas SHA-3 is the newest and most advanced family member.

Q23. What is an audit trail in e-signature platforms?

- **Definition:** It is a log that documents the entire signing process of an electronic document.
- **Role:** It provides additional evidence of the signature's validity and the chronological steps taken during signing.

Q24. Who created MD5 and for what primary purpose?

- **Creator:** MD5 was created by Ronald Rivest in 1991.
- **Purpose:** Its primary purpose was to enable the verification of digital signatures.

Q25. What happens if a recipient cannot open a document with a signer's public key?

- **Indication:** It indicates there is a problem with the document or the signature.
- **Conclusion:** This failure means the digital signature cannot be authenticated and should not be trusted.

